
SESSION 3E

EVANGELISM: HABITS TO FORM

INTRODUCTION

MATTHEW 28:18-20 (ESV)

¹⁸ And Jesus came and said to them, “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me.

¹⁹ Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, ²⁰ teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age.”



The Great Commission is not an option to be considered; it is a command to be obeyed.

– Hudson Taylor

MATTHEW 28:18-20 (ESV)

³⁵ And Jesus went throughout all the cities and villages, teaching in their synagogues and proclaiming the gospel of the kingdom and healing every disease and every affliction. ³⁶ When he saw the crowds, he had compassion for them, because they were harassed and helpless, like sheep without a shepherd. ³⁷ Then he said to his disciples, “The harvest is plentiful, but the laborers are few; ³⁸ therefore pray earnestly to the Lord of the harvest to send out laborers into his harvest.”

Identify some barriers, fears, or concerns you have when it comes to sharing the Gospel with others.

What’s one way that you want to grow in the area of evangelism?

MOTIVATIONS FOR EVANGELISM

[W]e are compelled by *the knowledge that those without Christ are lost and without hope*. Paul expressed this compulsion in Romans 9:1-3: "I am speaking the truth in Christ—I am not lying; my conscience bears me witness in the Holy Spirit—that I have great sorrow and unceasing anguish in my heart. For I could wish that I myself were accursed and cut off from Christ for the sake of my brothers, my kinsmen according to the flesh." The passage goes on to show that the reason for this compulsion was the fact that the Jews had rejected the gospel and were thus lost.¹

- Ajith Fernando, *Jesus Driven Ministry*

The vision of lostness was a strong motivating force in the lives of some of the heroes of Christian history. The seventeenth-century Scottish preacher Samuel Rutherford once told a person, "I would lay my dearest joys in the gap between you and eternal destruction." Hudson Taylor said, "I would have never thought of going to China had I not believed that the Chinese were lost and needed Christ." D.L. Moody told an audience in London, "If I believed there was not hell, I am sure I would be off tomorrow for America." He said he would give up going from town to town and spending day and night 'urging men to escape the damnation of hell.' William Booth said he would wish that his Salvation Army workers could spend "one night in hell" in order to see the urgency of their evangelistic task.²

- Ajith Fernando, *Crucial Questions About Hell*

No skill of ours is going to be able to lead an inquirer to Christ. That is the sovereign work of the Spirit Himself. We never know whether our frail attempts to make the truth and challenge of the gospel plain to a friend will be crowned with success or not. The marvelous thing is that we do not have to concern ourselves too much about it. Our call is to be faithful stewards of the treasure of the gospel, which has been given into our charge. The Spirit's task is to apply it.³

- Michael Green, *Evangelism Through the Local Church*

Prayer confirms our working relationship with the Holy Spirit in our ministry of witness and reconciliation. We are to complement what God is already doing in those he wants to bring to himself. We know that God has reserved for himself the responsibility of convicting people of their sin (John 16:8-11). We are assigned to speak the truth in love (Ephesians 4:15) and to be salt and light in our people worlds (Matthew 5:13-16 and Luke 13:21). Prayer unites us with God in our shared mission.

Praying for the people who share our lives heightens our awareness of them. We pray for roommates and neighbors - by name. We pray for colleagues and lab partners. In order that we will not be silent when we should speak, we ask our heavenly Father to help us understand what our friends believe and where they are in their relationship with him. We pray that we will recognize lonely people in crowded cafeterias and risk inviting ourselves to share their table. We pray for friends and members of our families and for the individuals we don't naturally like but who keep hanging around us. We pray that we will speak with care and act as Jesus would around such people. Asking that they may be open to being taught God's truth, we pray for those who teach us or those we teach.

But we also pray for ourselves...that we will be released from excessive preoccupation with ourselves so we can really listen to others. We pray that God will help us overcome our fears of being rejected and of being thought by others to be "too religious." We pray that we will both see and make opportunities to love and witness appropriately.⁴

- Don Posterski, *"Why Am I Afraid to Tell You I'm a Christian?"*

¹ Fernando, Ajith. *Jesus Driven Ministry*. Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway Books, 2002. p. 118.

² Fernando, Ajith. *Crucial Questions About Hell*. Wheaton, Illinois: Crossway Books, 1994. pp. 143-145.

³ Green, Michael. *Evangelism Through the Local Church*. New York: Thomas Nelson Inc., 1992.

⁴ Posterski, Don. *"Why Am I Afraid to Tell You I'm A Christian?"* Westmont, Illinois: Intervarsity Press, 1983.

What phrases were most inspiring or challenging for you?

What points addressed some of your fears or concerns about evangelism?

THE FIVE-AND-FIVE PRINCIPLE

Think about the people in your life. List five people who are not open to you sharing your faith with them. They may be cold, skeptical, suspicious, unconcerned, or even hostile toward what you would like to tell them about Christ and what He has done and is doing in you. Although you want to share your faith with them so they also can become Christians, they are not willing to hear what you have to say.

Is there anything you can do that will enable you to reach them with the message of Christ? YES! YOU CAN PRAY FOR THEM!

Think about five people in your life who are open to you sharing your faith with them. They may not be ready to place their faith in Christ, but wonder about the differences they see Christ making in your life.

Use the chart to list the names of the 10 persons you identified.

Five friends who refuse to let me share Christ with them.	Five friends who are open to me sharing Christ.
1.	1.
2.	2.
3.	3.
4.	4.
5.	5.